

■■ Feature Fatigue

■ What is it?

Too many features can overwhelm users.

More features don't always make a product better. In fact, they can make it harder to use.

For example, a smartwatch with hundreds of settings may look powerful, but if all you want is to check your steps, it quickly feels exhausting.

■■ History

The term **Feature Fatigue** was introduced in consumer research studies (2000s) that showed people often choose feature-rich products when buying, but later regret their complexity when using them.

This highlights the gap between **purchase decisions** (driven by more features) and **real use** (where simplicity matters most).

■ The Psychology Behind It

- People focus on **quantity over quality** at purchase time.
- More features create an **illusion of value** but often reduce usability.
- Once in use, the overload makes it harder to find what's important, raising frustration.

This leads to low adoption of features, product abandonment, or poor reviews despite strong functionality.

■■ Why It Matters

Feature fatigue can cause:

- Confusion and overwhelm
- Poor usability
- Low feature adoption
- Abandonment of the product
- Higher learning curve

- Negative reviews despite rich functionality

■ How to Apply It

- **Prioritize core features** → focus on essentials.
- **Use progressive disclosure** → show more options only when needed.
- **Offer simple onboarding** → guide users gently, not all at once.
- **Let users customize** → hide or turn off unused features.

■ Theory in Action

- **Google Search** begins with only a simple box and button, revealing filters and tools only after results appear.
- **BMW 7 Series (745)** overloaded its dashboard with 700+ features, overwhelming drivers and reducing usability, leading to frustration and distraction.

■ Final Thought

More isn't always better.

A feature-packed product might look impressive on paper, but real users want **clarity, ease, and value**.

Good design balances functionality with simplicity—keeping users engaged without overwhelming them.